

FOR ONCE, SHASHI THAROOR IS AT A LOSS FOR WORDS. ASKED WHAT HE CALLS the burgundy red election *vahanam* (vehicle) he is perched precariously atop during a drive-through campaign rally in the heart of Thiruvananthapuram, he pauses and then laughs. "It's a pick-up truck that gives me a chair and enough space for a couple of colleagues so that we can wave to the public as we drive by." It's hot and humid in Kerala's capital city and all that protects Tharoor from the sun and rain is a makeshift tarpaulin over his head and a compact air-conditioner next to his perch. Having won three consecutive Lok Sabha elections for the Thiruvananthapuram constituency on a Congress ticket, Tharoor, 68, is a veteran at campaigning. He waves furiously to pedestrians, passing and stationary vehicles and curious shopkeepers, his face lighting up with a charming smile as the breeze tousles his silvery-grey mane. His pilot van has a band of percussionists belting out drum rolls to herald his arrival, while another van blasts songs in his praise on repeat. Unlike in 2019, when Tharoor breezed through his re-election to the seat with a high margin of votes, this time round, he is feeling the heat of the battle and is being made to toil harder.

WHILE THE BJP HAS NEVER WON A LOK SABHA SEAT IN KERALA, THAROOR ADMITS THE FIGHT IS TOUGHER, WITH THE PARTY EMERGING AS AN ALTERNATIVE

That's because his prime opponent is the tech-savvy and urbane Rajeev Chandrasekhar, a squire from the world of telecom and IT who built his own investment sultanate and then turned politician, also becoming a three-term parliamentarian, as a Rajya Sabha member. In his first two terms, the bearded Chandrasekhar was nominated as an Independent, but was inducted as a member of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) in his third and is currently the Union minister of state for electronics and information technology as well as for skill development and entrepreneurship. This may be the 59-year-old Chandrasekhar's first shot at contesting a political election, but he points out that the process is not new for him as he has handled campaigns for fellow partymen in the past. Though his parents are from Kerala, Chandrasekhar has never lived in the state, but it's not seen as a disadvantage as Tharoor had been parachuted into the state too. Chandrasekhar's *vahanam* is a modified vintage Mahindra Thar with its seats stripped off and its windshield bolted to the bonnet. When the muscular SUV pulls up at a roadside meeting venue, in addition to a drum roll announcement like that for Tharoor, a cannon fires a shower of confetti on him—in saffron, white and green colours of the BJP flag.

Both Tharoor and Chandrasekhar frequently engage each other in verbal jousts. At a meeting with ex-armed forces personnel recently, Chandrasekhar took a jibe at Tharoor's famed eloquence, confessing that he didn't have the time to read books and peruse dictionaries to come up with new English words to match his rival, but instead focuses on getting the job done. When Chandrasekhar filed his nomination papers for the seat, he talked of it as "a battle of performance vs non-performance". To which Tharoor shot back: "'Performance' has two meanings. One is what I have done for my constituency in the past 15 years—a 60-page report in Malayalam and English gives details of what I have done. The other meaning is 'acting' or 'theatre performance'. That's what the BJP is all about—perform-